

In this chapter, I'll provide several common ways of writing idiomatic Python code along with their unpythonic counterparts. What counts as pythonic can vary from programmer to programmer, but it commonly includes the examples and practices I discuss here. Experienced Python programmers use these techniques, so becoming familiar with them allows you to recognize them in real-world code.

The Zen of Python

The Zen of Python by Tim Peters is a set of 20 guidelines for the design of the Python language and for Python programs. Your Python code doesn't necessarily have to follow these guidelines, but they're good to keep in mind. The Zen of Python is also an *Easter egg*, or hidden joke, that appears when you run `import this`:

```
>>> import this
The Zen of Python, by Tim Peters

Beautiful is better than ugly.
Explicit is better than implicit.
--snip--
```

NOTE

Mysteriously, only 19 of the guidelines are written down. Guido van Rossum, creator of Python, reportedly said that the missing 20th aphorism is “some bizarre Tim Peters in-joke.” Tim left it blank for Guido to fill, which he seems to never have gotten around to doing.

In the end, these guidelines are opinions that programmers can argue for or against. Like all good sets of moral codes, they contradict themselves to provide the most flexibility. Here's my interpretation of these aphorisms:

Beautiful is better than ugly. Beautiful code can be thought of as easy to read and understand. Programmers often write code quickly without concern for readability. The computer will run unreadable code, but unreadable code is difficult for human programmers to maintain and debug. Beauty is subjective, but code that is written without regard for how understandable it is often ugly to others. The reason for Python's